Georgia Elects Keisha Lance Bottoms as First Black Woman Governor in U.S. History

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Georgia voters made history this week. They elected Keisha Lance Bottoms as the state's first Democratic governor in more than two decades, and the first Black woman ever elected governor in the United States.

Bottoms is the former mayor of Atlanta. She campaigned on lowering the cost of living, expanding access to health care, and pushing back against the Trump administration. She will take office in a state where Republicans still control the Senate, so she will need their support to pass many of her plans.

The victory is deeply personal for her. Her family has lived in Georgia for at least five generations, and she can trace her roots to a **plantation** in Crawfordville, where her great-great-grandparents were once **enslaved**. 'To have come from people who had to **toil** the soil of Georgia, and to now be elected governor has exceeded every dream that I ever had for my life,' she said.

Bottoms said the win was the result of decades of work by many people across Georgia, including groups that never appear on national news. Georgia has not elected a Democratic governor since 1998. She said she has not yet spoken with Stacey Abrams, who ran for governor herself and spent years building the political network that helped make Georgia **competitive** for Democrats.

Her message for the national Democratic Party is to listen to voters and focus on the issues that shape daily life, especially the cost of living. Democrats also won the Georgia House this time and are one seat away from controlling the Senate. 'We're going to try and find those things that we can get **bipartisan** agreement on,' Bottoms said, 'those things we can get done immediately.'

Word Treasure

bipartisan -- Bipartisan means people from two different political parties working together.

plantation -- A plantation is a large farm where crops were grown long ago, often by enslaved workers.

enslaved -- Enslaved means forced to work for someone else with no freedom and no pay.

toil -- To toil means to work very hard for a long time.

competitive -- Competitive means both sides have a real chance of winning.

Background you need

A governor is the leader of a state's government, in charge of carrying out state laws and working with the state's lawmakers on new plans.

In Georgia, the governor works with two lawmaking groups, the House and the Senate, and needs their agreement to pass most new laws.

Voters choose a governor in an election, and candidates often campaign on everyday issues such as the cost of living and health care.

Bottoms previously served as mayor of Atlanta before running for governor.

Break it down

LEAD: Georgia voters elect Keisha Lance Bottoms, the first Black woman ever elected governor in the United States.

KEY EVENT: Bottoms wins the governor's race as the state's first Democratic governor in more than two decades.

+- WHO: Keisha Lance Bottoms, former mayor of Atlanta

+- WHAT SHE RAN ON: lowering the cost of living, expanding access to health care, and pushing back against the Trump administration

+- PERSONAL STORY: Her family has lived in Georgia for at least five generations, and her great-great-grandparents were once enslaved on a plantation in Crawfordville.

+- WHAT HELPED: Decades of work by many people across Georgia, including groups that never appear on national news, and Stacey Abrams building the political network that helped make Georgia competitive for Democrats.

+- WHAT COMES NEXT: She will need Republican support in the Senate to pass many of her plans, while Democrats won the House and are one seat away from controlling the Senate.

EVIDENCE: Bottoms says she will try to find things with bipartisan agreement that can get done immediately.

OPEN QUESTION: Which of her plans will win support from the Republican-controlled Senate?

Why it matters

A governor's choices shape daily life in a state, from the cost of living to health care, and this election also shows how years of organizing by many people can change who holds power.

Test what you remember

1. What historic first did Keisha Lance Bottoms achieve in this election?

(A) She became the first Democratic governor of Georgia
(B) She became the first Black woman elected to the Georgia Senate
(C) She became the first woman mayor of Atlanta
(D) She became the first Black woman ever elected governor in the United States

2. What job did Bottoms hold before she ran for governor?

(A) Georgia state senator
(B) United States senator
(C) Member of the Georgia House
(D) Mayor of Atlanta

3. When was the last time before this election that Georgia elected a Democratic governor?

(A) 1998
(B) 2002
(C) 2010
(D) 1990

4. What did Bottoms say about her family's roots in Georgia?

(A) Her ancestors founded the town of Crawfordville
(B) Her family moved to Georgia last year
(C) Her great-great-grandparents were once enslaved on a plantation in Crawfordville
(D) Her family has lived in Georgia for one generation

5. Who did Bottoms say she had not yet spoken with after the election?

(A) The mayor of Atlanta
(B) Donald Trump
(C) The leader of the Georgia Senate
(D) Stacey Abrams

6. What else did Democrats win in this election, besides the governor's race?

(A) The Atlanta city council
(B) The Georgia Senate
(C) The United States Senate
(D) The Georgia House

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: A 4: C 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Keisha Lance Bottoms: She says the Democratic Party should listen to voters and focus on daily-life issues like the cost of living, and she wants to find things with bipartisan agreement that can get done immediately.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):